

RISE OF THE REST 5.4%

is the share of children's channels in the TV viewing market in 2008, up from 2.7 per cent in 2004.

time soap with *Aap ki Kachehri* with Kiran Bedi. The reasoning? If daytime soaps can run on prime time for eight years than why can't a spin-off of Court TV, another daytime staple in the US, do well?

Add to that a strike by the Federation of Western India Cine Workers for better wages and working conditions from the Association of Motion Picture and TV Programme Producers that doesn't look like ending any time soon and it is clear that an era has ended and another is emerging. What's that going to be? Here's a little trendspotting.

Loud is out, low key is in

No more zip zap zooms and multiple generation leaps. The Zee TV alumni which launched *Saat Phere* three years ago, the first daily soap to shatter the *Kyunki* monopoly on television, are everywhere and they have taken with them a more believable sensibility. Vivek Bahl, who was the creative head of Zee TV when *Saat Phere* was launched, powered *Bidaai* and *Raja Ki Aayegi Baraat* on Star Plus. The writer of *Saat Phere*, Purnendu Shekhar and the producer Sunjoy Wadhwa, have created *Balika Vadhu*. One of the unofficial ten commandments of TV is untouched in both these shows. The girl, between 15 and 35, is not too beautiful, is home-bound, and is always in suffering-sacrificing mode. But it's the way *Balika Vadhu* is shot

that is different. There are few visual clichés, the cutting is smooth and dialogue doesn't equal din.

Disruptive scheduling

Reality shows over the weekdays? Colors tried that with the 16-episode *Khatron ke Khiladi* and it worked, giving the infant channel a big buzz. They have also played *Balika Vadhu*, their star soap, at 8 p.m., a slot regarded as early prime time, but on second

thoughts now emerging as the perfect down time between the cooking and the eating of dinner. Colors was also smart in taking the reality format out of the song and dance stranglehold. It worked. So while the rest of the channels try and fight the sameness of *naach-gana* shows, they went from *Khatron ke Khiladi* to *Big Boss*. The biggest casualty of the sameness so far has been Zee TV's *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*, which despite better judges and singers, is languishing in the ratings.

